



**Productive stint:** From talent hunts in Srinagar (top) to training camps in Vadodara (below), Irfan Pathan's tenure as J&K mentor focused on discovering new players and building a cohesive squad. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

belief, and belief translated into results.

In the 2019–20 Ranji Trophy season, we qualified for the quarterfinals. It was not just a statistical achievement — it validated the philosophy.

One of my primary targets was expanding the fast-bowling pool. In a long domestic season, you cannot survive with three or four seamers. You need eight to 10 options to deal with injuries, dips in form and varied conditions.

In 2018, we travelled extensively — from Anantnag to Kupwara to Baramulla — conducting trials and talent hunts. In Srinagar, hundreds of

boys often turned up for open trials. I would sit there from 9:30 in the morning until 5 in the evening, watching each one carefully. It was exhausting but incredibly rewarding.

That is how we identified talents such as Rasikh Salam, Umran Malik and Auqib Nabi. They were not polished products. They were raw, hungry and fearless. Our job was to give them structure and exposure.

One of the players discovered during that phase was Abdul Samad. He was spotted at a trial camp in Jammu. The trials were being held at the SPMR Science College ground, and most players were struggling on the wicket. But Samad stood out immediately. He played on the up and struck the ball cleanly.

When I spoke to the selectors and some local coaches, they said Samad would score attractive 20s and 25s but rarely play long innings.

I told them that was fine. If a player can produce impactful 20s and

25s, we can build from there. The talent was obvious. What he needed was exposure and belief.

So we brought him into the squad for the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. Even that decision went against the tide, because many felt he was still raw. But I believed he could make a difference.

Rasikh's story was similar. In fact, he was not even among the 30 probables in junior cricket at that stage. I first noticed him during a trial at the Sher-i-Kashmir Cricket Stadium in Srinagar, where around 90 players were participating.

He bowled just two deliveries. That was enough for me to realise he had something special — the pace, the action, the natural ability.

We immediately included him among the 30 probables for the senior team.

I knew it would raise eyebrows because he had not featured in the junior probables before. But sometimes you must trust what your eyes tell you.

There were several other players who came through that process. Basit Bashir, a left-arm pacer, was another example. He had played some junior cricket, and we identified him during a district-level match in Kupwara. I travelled there specifically to watch matches at the Kupwara ground.

Those days were all about scouting and creating opportunities. Most camps and trials were held in Jammu or Srinagar, but we ensured matches were played across districts to identify talent from every corner of the region. The idea was simple: if there was talent anywhere in Jammu and Kashmir, we wanted to find it and give it a platform.

Infrastructure posed another hurdle. Many boys were used to matting wickets. Transitioning to turf pitches was crucial for long-term development. But that required transporting rollers, curators and equipment across districts — no small task in a geographically challenging region.

Yet, once facilities improved, the standard of training rose immediately.